

technologies could revolutionise the comfort levels we already enjoy.

The technologies we speak of in what follows are arranged in order of the impact they've had on our lives.

The PC

The PC began way back in 1973 with the ALTO, developed by Xerox. This wasn't released to the public, as they didn't think there was a market for this sort of product—famous last words!

The first publicly available PC was the Altair 8800, developed by Ed Roberts. Fast-forward to the present day, and thanks to all the battles and wars raging between manufacturers of various PC



The Xerox ALTO was perhaps the first development in the PC business. However, Xerox misjudged the need for a PC and never sold it. One of Xerox's biggest mistakes

components, a PC is today cheaper than ever before. There are hundreds of billions of dollars being spent and earned on PCs, and jobs that did not exist just a decade ago are now some of the highest-paying ones.

The PC has become our primary interface with technology. Almost everything technology-related we do needs a PC in one way or another, whether it's gaming, programming, accounts, printing, surfing or e-mail. There's no doubt that the PC wins hands down as the technology that vastly changed our lives!

The Internet

If the PC changed our lives, the Internet enhanced the way your PC could be put to use, and, in a very real sense, made the world a truly tiny place.

What started out as a bulletin board style of exchanging information has now taken over our lives in ways we do not imagine. Take simple e-



People often confuse the "Internet" with the World Wide Web (WWW). The truth is that though no one person invented the Internet, the WWW was the brainchild of just one man—Sir Timothy Berners-Lee. Thanks to Berners-Lee (left), all of us can surf the WWW and find the information we need

mail for instance: at a time when official and personal communication had to be done over the telephone or via snail mail, e-mail gave us all the ease of sending a message, letter, business quotation and more, to someone across the world in a matter of seconds.

The beauty of e-mail was that, just like post or snail mail, a message could be delivered to a person even if he wasn't in at work on that day—a phone call, instead, meant that both people had to be present at their respective phone instruments to "talk".

However, e-mail is not the only thing the Internet has given us; you can use it to find information, people, services, adult content, images and so much more. Thanks to the Internet, you can now chat in real time, via text and even voice and video, with someone at the other end of the world—and all this at minimal cost!

Innumerable Web-based companies started that have no 'brick-and-mortar' presence in the form of an office or anything 'concrete', but still earn millions of dollars a year through services. There are also Web sites that help you or your company get work contracts such as www.renta-coder.com and www.elance.com. Then there are the evils of file sharing and P2P, which have been a boon to most users and a bane to the movie and music industry.

Thanks to the Internet, we've created a completely virtual world, in which we have communities that contain everything that you see in regular society—friends from across the world, criminals (hackers), people looking to cheat you, shady deals, dating sites, matrimonial sites, in other words, a huge resource for learning that's bigger than any library in the world.

It's not an exaggeration to say that the Internet has enabled us to go beyond our bodies; we've gotten very close indeed to "social virtual reality"—as anyone who "lives" on the Internet will affirm. And that's just scratching the surface of the Internet. The Internet really is the best example of a technology that has changed our lives!

Mobile Computing

Just a few years ago, we were starting to get used to doing everything on a computer. Laptops were for rich folks, and mobile phones were not powerful enough to handle everyday computing needs. Then entered the new breed of devices that changed that situation forever. Though they used age-old wireless data transfer ideas, mobile



Imagine every child using a tablet PC at school; it's not impossible or even improbable, this is a photo from an actual school in Japan! All thanks to Mobile Computing